hailing from the south Indian state of Tamil Nadu—had asked Bhadrakumar to consolidate India's relations with the authorities in Kabul, reopen India's mission there, and request Massoud to let Najibullah fly to India (though this was an ancillary issue).[31] Massoud refused, claiming that letting Najibullah go would not be agreeable to other Mujahideen leaders.

Bhadrakumar retrospectively thinks that Massoud viewed Najibullah as a potential political asset given his ethnic and political background. But it is highly possible that the Panjshiri leader wanted to ensure that Najibullah did not become New Delhi's 'trump card' in Afghanistan, and wanted to reserve that spot for himself.[32] Srinivasan concurs: 'We would have been very happy to have Najib[ullah] in Delhi ... and not that it was a consideration of ours but he would have had some political traction in Afghanistan [even afterwards], and that was why the Tajiks refused to let him go ... because they felt that if he enjoyed some residual traction and if was supported by India, he could have a political future in Afghanistan which would be to their detriment'.[33] While the real reasons why Massoud took this decision remain unknown, it is true that Najibullah's wife, Fatana, resented New Delhi's tilt towards Massoud. Nambiar says, it was a '*dharam-sankat*' (moral dilemma) for her to support India's seemingly anti-Pashtun, and in this case even anti-Najibullah, tilt toward the United Front in order to counter-balance Pakistan and the Taliban (despite the fact that the Taliban assassinated her husband).[34] She never forgave Massoud (and Dostum) for stopping Najibullah from leaving Kabul, the UN for failing in its responsibility to secure Najibullah's release, and then for New Delhi to work closely with these men.[35] These assessments, however, still don't explain why Massoud left Najibullah in the UN compound in 1996 while retreating to the safety of Panjshir under attack from the Taliban. Perhaps he genuinely believed that keeping Najibullah hostage was an article of faith and releasing him would undermine his authority among his Mujahideen associates? Either way, while some Afghan officials still thank India for hosting Najibullah's wife and daughters,[36] others complain that India did not stand up for its friend when he needed New Delhi's support the most.[37] India's pro-Najibullah Afghanistan policy, as reflected in those highly tense but crystal clear moments, ended in failure. New Delhi's inability to protect Najibullah, furthermore, earned it the